MAJOR SUIT OPENINGS

*Note: This lesson assumes you are **NOT** playing the 2-over-1 Game Force system.*
*Note: This lesson assumes you are **NOT** playing Jacoby 2NT for strong Major raises.*
If you are playing either of these conventions you don't need this lesson.

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

Although it is not included in the Deals you might wish to examine your and dummy's hand and make a Plan of how you would play the contract.

MAJOR SUIT OPENINGS

Opening bids:

To open 1♥ or 1♠ you should have a least 5 cards in the suit. Any 5 cards will do, even 6 5 4 3 2.

You should also have between 13 and 21 points. Well, maybe 12 good points will do.

Here are some examples of a 1♥ opening bid.

♠ 9 8 3 ♥ A K Q 9 3 ♦ K 7 ♣ 9 7 6

♠ A 6 2 ♥ 9 8 7 5 3 ♦ A 4 ♣ A 6 5

♠ K 7 3 ♥ A K Q J 6 ♦ A Q ♣ 8 3 2

♠ 5 ♥ Q J 9 7 4 2 ♦ K Q 3 ♣ A Q 4

You might have opened hand #3 with 2NT, but probably not.

Responses:

With fewer than three cards in partner's suit use these responses.

Points	Response
0-5	pass
6-10	bid new suit at 1 level or bid 1NT
11-16	bid new suit at 1 or 2 level
13-15	bid 2NT if balanced

If you do have at least three cards in partner's Major suit, then you already know of the 8-card fit and

can be pretty sure you will end up playing in that suit. These responses apply.

Points	Recommended Response
0-5	pass with 3 or 4 card support
6-10	raise partner to 2-level
10-12	limit raise; jump to 3-level
13-15	bid a new suit (forcing) then bid 4 of the Major
0-9	bid game with 5 card support

This set of bids isn't universally agreed.
Some don't use the weak jump to game even though it is there primarily for preemptive purposes. Others switch the third and fourth bids, using a jump to the 3-level as forcing to game and a new suit then 3 of the Major as the 11-12 point hand.

We recommend sticking to the table, and have used this system throughout the examples.

Opener Rebids:

Once Responder shows at least 6 points with a response Opener puts his hand into one of three categories:

Points	Category	Rebids
13-15	Minimum	Rebid the Major suit if 6-cards Bid a new lower-ranking suit Bid cheapest notrump
16-18	Medium	Jump rebid a 6-card Major Bid a new suit Jump in NT or partner's suit
19-21	Maximum	Jump rebid a 6-card Major Jump shift in a new suit Jump to 3NT or game in partner's suit

By now either Opener or Responder may be in a position to place the contract, or another bid may be needed.

Help Suit Game Try:

Suppose you have a hand like this:
♠A 6 ♥A K Q 9 3 ♦K 7 6 3 ♣9 3

You open 1♥ partner responds 2♥. You have agreed on the trump suit, but now have to figure out how high. You have 17/18 points and partner has shown 6-10 so you know the total is between 23 and 28. Not strong enough to bid game, but good enough to invite to game.

The "normal" invitational bid you might make is 3♥. This would tell partner to check his points and pass if he has 6 or 7, but go to game if he has 9 or 10. With 8 he would have to make a judgement call.

A better invitational bid is 3♦, a suit you could use "Help" in. This bid in no way changes the fact that you are going to end up in ♥s since that is already agreed. What it does is helps partner if he has a close call. With 9 or 10 points he should go to game regardless, but with 8 (maybe 7) he should look at his ♦ holding to see if he can help you in the suit. If so, he bids the game, if not, he returns to 3♥.

With this hand he would bid 3♥:
♠ K 7 ♥ J 8 5 4 ♦ 5 4 2 ♣ Q J 9 2

But with this hand he would bid 4♥:
♠ K 7 ♥ J 8 5 4 ♦ Q J 9 2 ♣ 5 4 2

20 examples will be worth more than another 1000 words.

Board: 1
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣2

Board: 2
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦2

Board: 3
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♣K

Board: 4
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: West
Lead: ♥10

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦6

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♣Q

Board 1
South Deals
None Vul

	♠ K 9 7 3 ♥ 5 ♦ K Q 6 4 ♣ Q 8 7 6	
♠ J 2 ♥ 10 7 3 2 ♦ 9 5 3 ♣ K 10 9 5		♠ Q 8 4 ♥ Q J 9 ♦ A J 10 8 ♣ J 4 2
	♠ A 10 6 5 ♥ A K 8 6 4 ♦ 7 2 ♣ A 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♥
Pass	1♠	Pass	3♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♣2

You dealt this hand.

Naturally you open 1♥. Partner responds 1♠. What do you say next?

Partner has at least 4 ♠s and you have 4. So you have found the 8-card Major fit. Now it is a question of finding the right level. Your job is to further describe your hand as either minimum, medium, or maximum. With 17/18 points (revalued) you are a medium, so you jump to 3♠.

Partner bids the game.

Board 2
West Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 8 6 ♥ J 6 4 ♦ A 8 6 5 4 ♣ 9 5 2	
♠ K Q 9 7 3 ♥ A 10 9 5 ♦ Q J 3 ♣ 10		♠ A 4 ♥ Q 7 ♦ K 10 9 7 ♣ K Q J 8 6
	♠ J 10 5 2 ♥ K 8 3 2 ♦ 2 ♣ A 7 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♠	Pass	2♣	Pass
2♥	Pass	3NT	
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♦2

You dealt this hand.

Of course you open 1♠. Partner responds 2♣. What is your next bid?

Partner has shown at least 11 points and you are forced to bid again. Since the ♥s rank below ♠s you can bid them with your minimum hand. Apparently that is just what partner wanted to hear since he jumps to 3NT which you happily pass.

Board 3
North Deals
E-W Vul

♠ A 9 7 5 3
♥ Q J 10 5
♦ K Q J
♣ 7

♠ K 4
♥ 4 2
♦ 10 6 5 2
♣ K Q 10 4 2



♠ Q J 10 8
♥ A 8 6
♦ 9 7 3
♣ J 6 5

♠ 6 2
♥ K 9 7 3
♦ A 8 4
♣ A 9 8 3

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♠	Pass	2♥
Pass	4♥		
All Pass			

4♥ by South
Lead: ♣K

You dealt this hand.

You open 1♠ and partner responds 2♥.

Partner has shown 11+ points and at least 4 ♥s. Your hand revalues to 16 points in support of ♥s, where you know you have an 8-card fit or better. You bid 4♥ confidently.

Board 4
West Deals
Both Vul

	♠ J 9 ♥ 10 9 4 ♦ J 8 3 ♣ A Q 9 6 3	
♠ A K 10 7 5 3 ♥ Q J 5 ♦ K Q 10 ♣ 7		♠ Q 6 ♥ K 8 7 3 ♦ A 9 7 ♣ 10 8 5 4
	♠ 8 4 2 ♥ A 6 2 ♦ 6 5 4 2 ♣ K J 2	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
1♠	Pass	1NT	Pass
3♠	Pass	4♠	
All Pass			

4♠ by West
Lead: ♥10

You dealt this hand.

We all know you will open 1♠ with this hand. And after partner responds 1NT what is your next bid?

With 6 of them you can rebid ♠s but you are too strong to say just 2♠. Your 17 points puts you in the Medium range where you make a jump. So you bid 3♠ and partner bids 4♠.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 6 ♥ A Q J 9 8 ♦ A K 8 5 ♣ K Q J	
♠ Q J 9 8 3 ♥ 10 4 ♦ Q J 10 9 ♣ 6 4	N W E S	♠ K 7 5 4 ♥ 6 3 ♦ 6 2 ♣ 10 8 5 3 2
	♠ A 10 2 ♥ K 7 5 2 ♦ 7 4 3 ♣ A 9 7	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♥	Pass	3♥
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♥[2]
Pass	6♥		
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♥ by North
Lead: ♦6

You dealt this hand.

This is a big hand. But not quite enough to open 2♣. So you open 1♥ and partner responds 3♥. Now what?

You might bid 4♦ as a slam try, but it is probably just as well to go ahead and ask for Aces. So you bid 4NT and partner owns up to holding 2 Aces. What is your next bid?

You have all the Aces but don't go crazy. Partner only has 11-12 points so don't think too Grand! Bid 6♥.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ A Q 4 ♥ J 4 2 ♦ J 9 7 ♣ K 9 7 5	
♠ 9 8 7 ♥ 10 8 6 ♦ A Q 8 5 ♣ 6 3 2		♠ K 5 ♥ A K Q 7 5 ♦ K 6 3 ♣ A 10 8
	♠ J 10 6 3 2 ♥ 9 3 ♦ 10 4 2 ♣ Q J 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		1♥	Pass
2♥	Pass	4♥	
All Pass			

4♥ by East
Lead: ♣Q

The bidding has been as shown.

With 6 points you must respond and you should let partner know you have support for his suit. So you bid 2♥ and he promptly raises to 4♥. It's a good thing he had 20 points isn't it.